



Figure 4: Default openSUSE KDE with their customised Air theme

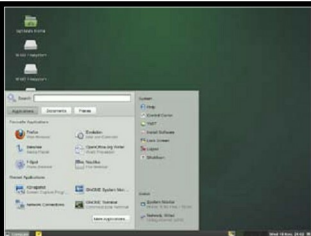


Figure 5: openSUSE's GNOME with the brand-new Sonar theme

Identi.ca and openDesktop.

On the technical front, you can now use BtrFS as your root partition, since it now has a stable disk layout! Other than that, the new partitioner in the installer does improve usability a lot. Coming to YaST, it seems to have stabilised a lot, and for the first time did not crash on my computer while installing openSUSE! Zypper can now download all packages before installing them, and GNOME has an updated Software Update application. And the new artwork stack is, again, Wow!

For netbookers, "...special attention has been paid to the netbook market, and new drivers will enable openSUSE to run better on a wider range of netbooks," says the website. Cool, uh?

Just an aside: When you first install OS11.2, your desktop may be unresponsive and you may experience massive disk thrashing. (This happened on my computer.) This is caused due to an anomaly in Beagle Desktop Search. To fix it, just switch to the console via Ctrl-Alt-F2, log in as the root user and run 'reboot'. Seriously, *that* fixes it.

Mandriva 2010.0—OMG! What's this?

It's a visual disaster—nothing has changed since the last release. Nothing at all! la Ora, the artwork stack of Mandriva (for... what, the last five decades?) has not changed and still shows the thick unbearable purple and blue colours. It's a look that actually reminds you of the golden age of computers—the 90s.

Mandriva does not fall behind when it wants to use the latest and the greatest software (KDE 4.3) but can't seem to resist making it behave like KDE1 either (no widgets, older style menu and panel, folder view and that obnoxious visual style—refer to Figure 6). So, ladies and gentlemen, what is the use of using KDE 4.3 if you are going to disable desktop widgets and fancy graphics anyway?

GNOME? Still the same desktop from the last four releases (Figure 7). No changes. Yet, it's the latest version, 2.28. Wake up, Mandriva devs! I thought you guys were interested in modernisation when you helped K3b port to Qt4! Quoting the *2010 Reviewer's Guide* at wiki.mandriva.

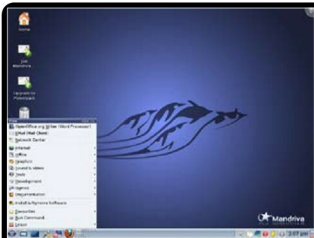


Figure 6: Mandriva's KDE4 tries to imitate KDE3



Figure 7: Mandriva's GNOME uses the same old la Ora theme